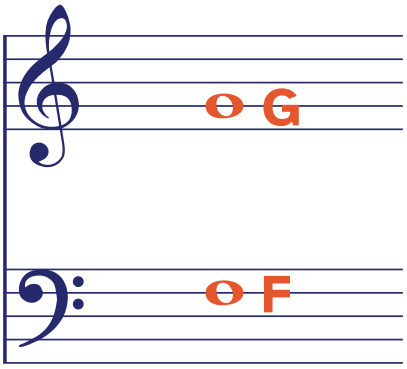
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

THE SECRET

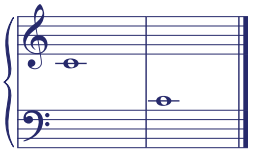
The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



The treble clef curls round G · the bass clef's dots hug F

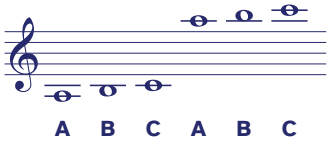
The grand staff

Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.

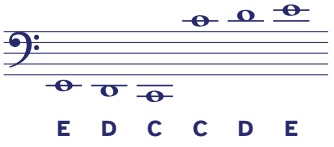


Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

Ledger lines: the staff carried on



Treble: A, B, C below; A, B, C above.



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

Notes too high or too low for the staff sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines. Read them by stepping on from the nearest staff line: line, space, line, space.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

8va: play it an octave higher

Lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a very high passage is written on the staff with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher**, eight notes up, until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the staff means an octave lower.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same five lines read as different notes, depending on which pair you put on.

EXAMPLE 1

One line, two notes

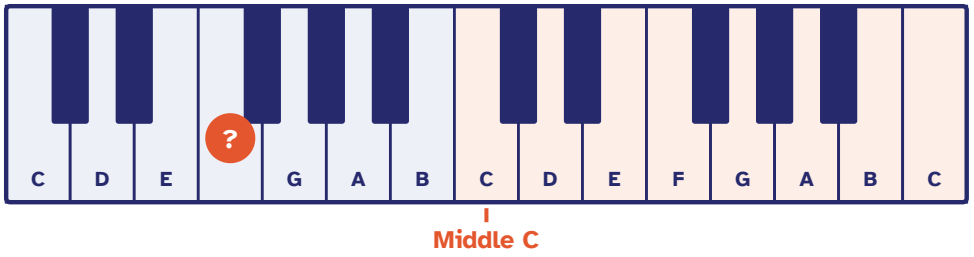


1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Read each from its clef note:** treble G is line 2, so step down (F in the space) to line 1; bass F is line 4, so step down line by line.

Treble bottom line: **E**. Bass bottom line: **G**. Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

EXAMPLE 2

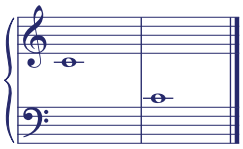
Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Point, then play.

Point to the line the treble clef curls round and play that G. Point to the line between the bass clef's dots and play that F. Middle C sits between them.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

GAME

Treble or bass?
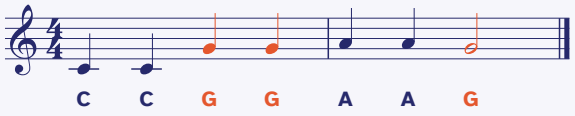
1	2	3	4
the E above Middle C	the lowest key on the piano	Middle C	High C

Which staff would each note be written on?

Answer: 1 treble · 2 bass, with ledger lines · 3 either: it sits between the two · 4 treble, two ledger lines up.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Middle C hangs on its own ledger line below.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

TRAP

- × Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.
- × Reading ledger lines from the wrong end: start at the staff and step outwards.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 28 · The staff and the keyboard p. 31

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

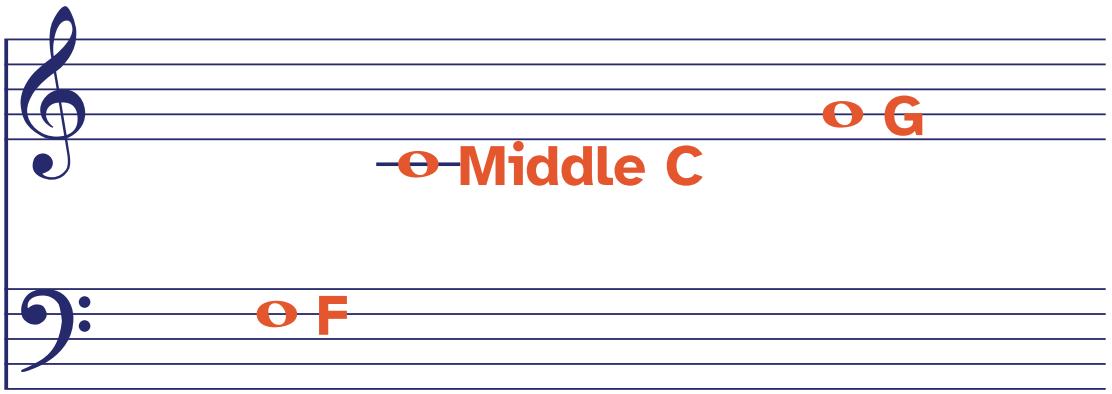
PART I · PITCH · 3

Reading the notes

Every line and space has one letter. You do not have to learn them all at once: start from a note you always know, then **step** or **skip** to the one you want.

THE SECRET

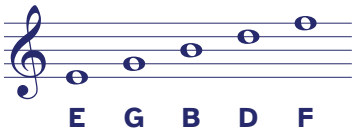
Start from a note you know (bass F, Middle C, treble G), then step or skip.



Three notes you always know: bass F, Middle C, treble G

THE RULE

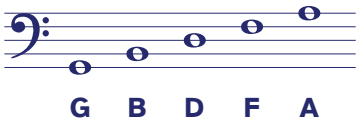
Step: to the very next line or space (one letter on). Skip: line to the next line, or space to the next space (two letters on).



Treble lines, E G B D F: *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*



Treble spaces, F A C E: they spell *FACE*



Bass lines, G B D F A: *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*

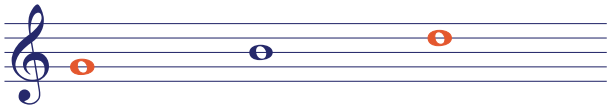


Bass spaces, A C E G: *All Cows Eat Grass*

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a note you are not sure of



1. **The clef:** treble, so the clef note is G, on line 2.
2. **From G, skip up** line to line: one letter jumped each time.
3. **Count the skips** up to the other red note, on line 4: G, then B, then …

The red note is **D**: G, B, D, two skips up from the clef's G.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a bass note from the clef



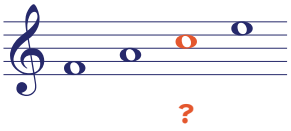
F E ?

1. **The bass clef's dots** sit either side of line 4: that line is F.
2. **Step down** to the space below.
3. **One more step down** to the red note on line 3.

F, E, **D**: bass line 3 is D, two steps down from the clef's F.

EXAMPLE 3

Find Treble C on the staff

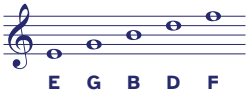


?

1. **These notes sit in the spaces.** The bottom space is F.
2. **Step up through the spaces:** F, A … they spell a word.
3. **The red note is space 3.** Which letter is it?

F A **C** E: space 3 is **C**, Treble C, the same C you found on the keyboard, one octave above Middle C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



E G B D F

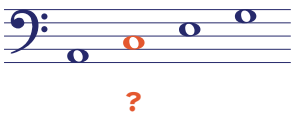
Say the treble lines up and down.

"E G B D F", then "F D B G E", out loud, as fast as you can without a slip. Then the spaces: "F A C E".

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find Bass C on the staff



1. **These notes sit in the bass spaces.** The bottom space is A: *All.*
2. **Say the next word:** *All Cows …*
3. **The red note is space 2.** Which letter?

A **C** E G: space 2 of the bass staff is **C**, Bass C, one octave below Middle C.

GAME

Name it from the clef note
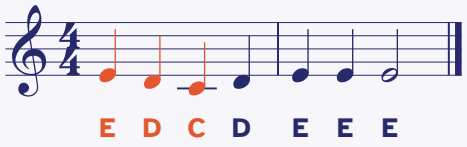
1	2	3	4
treble line 3	treble space 1	bass line 3	bass space 3

Start from the clef note (treble G on line 2, bass F on line 4), then step or skip.

Answer: 1 B (skip up from G) · 2 F (step down from G) · 3 D (two steps down from F) · 4 E (step down from F).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, ledger line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT The clef notes are lamp posts on a dark road: walk from the nearest one and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Mixing up step and skip: a step changes line to space; a skip stays on lines (or on spaces).

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 25 · The staff and the keyboard p. 31

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

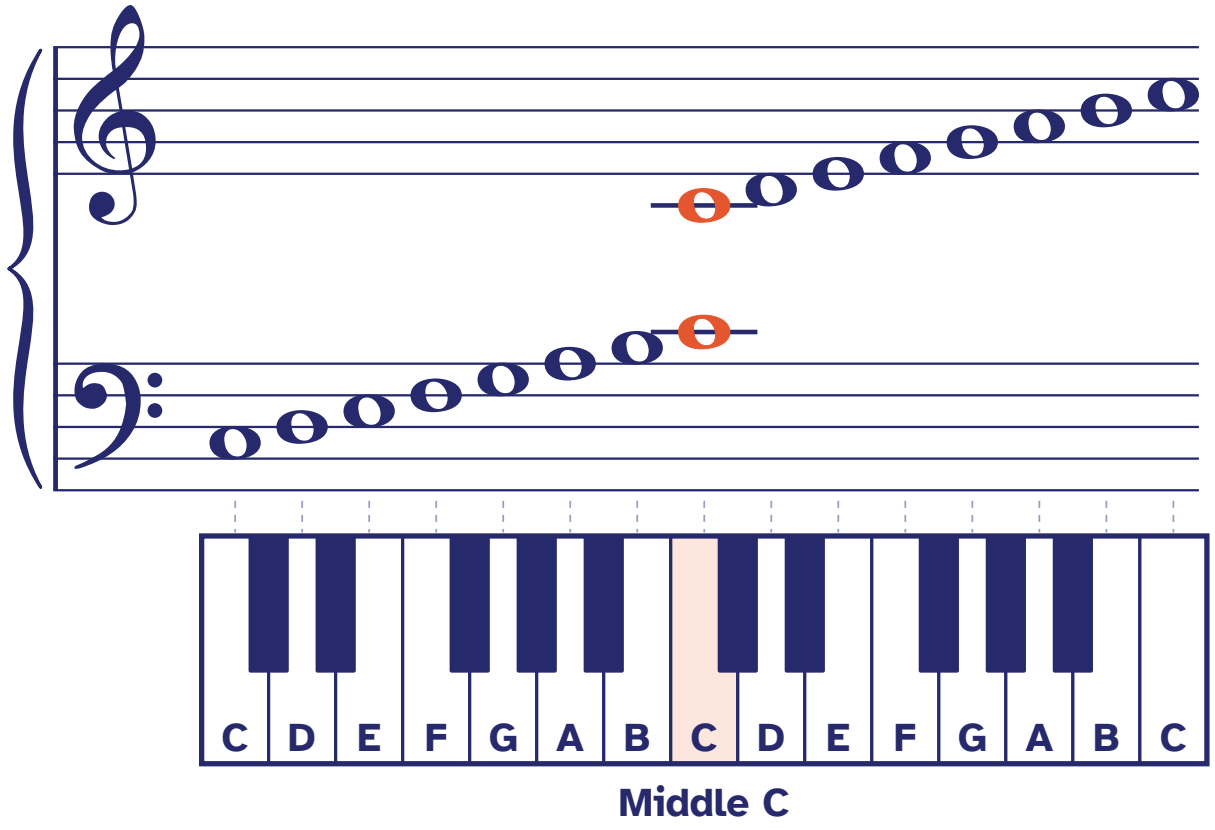
PART I · PITCH · 4

The staff and the keyboard

Each line and each space of the grand staff is one white key. Climb the staff and you climb the keyboard: here are two octaves, from Bass C to Treble C, with Middle C in red where the two staves meet.

THE SECRET

Every line and every space is one white key, in order.



Middle C can be written in either staff: on a ledger line below the treble staff, or above the bass staff. Same key; the hand that plays it chooses.

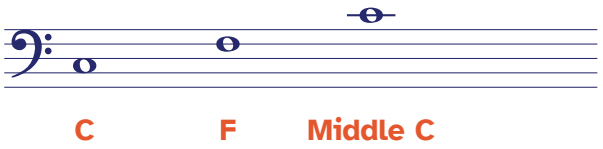
THE RULE

One step on the staff (line to space, or space to line) is the very next white key. Black keys have no line of their own: they borrow a white key's line with a sharp or flat (p. 34).

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

From the page to the key

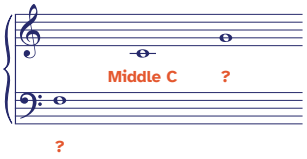


1. **Name the note:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **Find Middle C** on the piano, then count the notes down: C is 1, B 2, A 3 ...
3. **Stop on 5** and play it with the left hand.

C B A G **F**: the bass-clef F is note 5 counting down from Middle C.

EXAMPLE 2

Mirror notes either side of Middle C

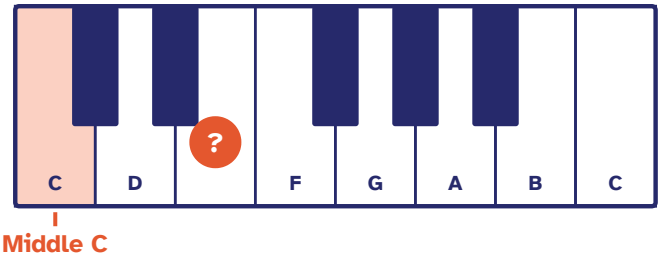


1. **Treble G:** count up from Middle C, C D E F G. Which number?
2. **Bass F:** count down from Middle C, C B A G F. Which number?
3. **Compare the two.**

Both are **note 5**: treble G and bass F are mirror images, the same distance either side of Middle C.

EXAMPLE 3

From the key to the page



1. **Find the ? key:** count up from Middle C, C 1, D 2 ...
2. **Do the same on the staff:** Middle C on its ledger line, D in the space under the staff ...
3. **Where do you land?**

The **?** is **E**, note 3, and it sits on the **bottom line** of the treble staff.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

GAME

Count the notes

1	2	3
Middle C up to A	Middle C down to E	G up to the next G

Count the notes, both ends included. The staff climbs the same way: one line or space per note.

Answer: 1 six (C D E F G A) · 2 six (C B A G F E) · 3 eight: an octave.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

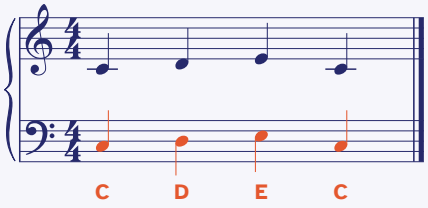


Play Middle C, then walk up.

Say each white key as you play it, C D E F G A B C, and picture each one climbing the staff: line, space, line, space.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques, in both hands



The left hand plays the **same letters**, C D E C, one octave lower, written in the bass clef.

Try it. Play it right hand, then left hand, then both together.

THINK OF IT The staff is a ladder laid beside the keyboard: each rung, a line or a space, is the next white key.

TRAP

- × Thinking the black keys have their own lines: they borrow a white key's line or space with a sharp or flat.
- × Counting from 0: the note you start on is note 1.

SEE ALSO

The keyboard p. 22 · Reading the notes p. 28

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 1–2 · Online: Library › Staff and clefs